

SlideCup — Coffee Cups With A Hidden Card

Every coffee works twice.

What It Is

A custom paper coffee cup with a secret card hidden on the outside. It looks like an ordinary cup, but slide the card out and it becomes a giveaway, a loyalty reward, a quiz, or a personalized message. Cafés use it to pull customers back again and again, and the surprise is so fun that people post it online — quietly turning every single cup of coffee into free marketing. You don't change the product; you change the experience around it.

How It Makes Money

You manufacture/import these hidden-card cups and sell them in bulk to cafés, coffee chains, bubble-tea shops, and event caterers. Revenue models: per-case wholesale of custom-printed cups, design/setup fees for the card artwork and loyalty mechanics, and recurring reorders (cups are a consumable — they run out and rebuy monthly). Add a SaaS-style upsell where the card drives a QR loyalty/feedback flow you help manage.

Startup Costs

- Initial inventory (custom hidden-card cups, 10k-25k units): **\$2,000-\$6,000** — Alibaba search "custom printed paper coffee cup with pull out card"
- Sample runs + print proofs from 2-3 suppliers: **\$200-\$700**
- Branding, design templates, mockups: **\$300-\$1,200**
- Shopify/B2B order site + photography: **\$400-\$1,500**
- Marketing / café outreach (samples to give away): **\$500-\$2,000**
- Business license + import handling: **\$300-\$1,200**
- Per-unit import note: custom hidden-card cups land around **\$0.06-\$0.15/unit** from China at 10k+ MOQ (vs. ~\$0.03-\$0.05 for a plain cup — the card adds modest cost for big perceived value).
- **Total to launch: ~\$3,500-\$11,000**

The Numbers

- Landed cost per cup: **~\$0.10**
- Sell wholesale at **\$0.22-\$0.35/cup** to cafés → profit **~\$0.12-\$0.25/cup**
- A café ordering 5,000 cups/month at \$0.28 = **\$1,400 order**, ~\$900 profit to you
- 15 café accounts averaging 4,000 cups/month → **~\$50,000/month gross**, **~\$18,000-\$25,000 profit**
- Cups are consumable, so accounts reorder every 2-4 weeks — recurring revenue compounds fast.

How To Start

1. Order sample hidden-card cups from 2-3 suppliers; test print quality and the slide mechanism.
2. Lock a reliable supplier and create easy custom-design templates for café branding.
3. Build a simple B2B order site with tiered bulk pricing and reorder buttons.
4. Print a small demo batch and hand free samples to local cafés to spark word of mouth.
5. Pitch the loyalty/marketing angle: "every cup brings the customer back and gets posted."

6. Land your first 5-10 café accounts and set them up on monthly reorders.
7. Add a QR-based loyalty/feedback layer as a premium upsell.

Where To Get Customers

- Direct B2B outreach to independent cafés, bubble-tea and juice shops, bakeries
- Free-sample drops to local cafés (the card sells itself in person)
- Coffee-supply distributors and café-equipment resellers as partners
- Event caterers, festivals, and brand activations wanting interactive cups
- Reels showing customers discovering the hidden card (drives inbound café interest)

Pro Tips

- Sell the loyalty mechanic, not the cup. Frame it as a marketing tool that brings customers back and generates posts — that justifies the premium over a plain cup.
- Cups are consumable, so chase reorders, not one-time sales. Set up auto-reorder and your revenue becomes recurring.
- Make the card do real work — a QR to a loyalty app or a prize. A blank novelty card wears off; a functional one becomes part of the café's retention system.